

Tawala Communications

Email Templates · Receipts · Invoices

Complete UI/UX Overhaul Audit

Source: backend/app/core/mailer.py · ReceiptClientView · CompleteSaleClient

Method: UX Engineering AUDIT + DESIGN mode against Canonical Modern Retail OS

Date: 2026-09-14 · Branch context: chore/theme-retail-os

This report audits every transactional email the product sends, plus on-screen and printable receipts/invoices. Findings are evidence-based from the repository. Target designs stay inside DESIGN.md tokens (petrol primary #003F4E, terracotta secondary, mint success, warm alabaster surfaces).

1. Executive summary

Emails and settlement documents still speak an earlier visual language (slate/indigo SaaS, mixed CTAs). Product UI has moved to the Modern Retail OS; communications have not. That gap erodes trust at the exact moments users decide to verify, invite, pay, or keep a paper trail.

Headline findings

- **P1 Brand drift in email:** Live templates use indigo (#4f46e5), sky (#0284c7), and slate chrome — not petrol primary.
- **P1 No shared email layout:** Each method inlines its own HTML; no master template, no dark-mode-safe or plain-text twin.
- **P1 Receipt vs invoice mental model:** One client view toggles mode via query string; hierarchy is better after redesign but still cart-dependent and placeholder branch data.
- **P2 Security copy uneven:** Password reset is stronger; onboarding/invite softer on expiry and unexpected-request guidance.
- **P2 Missing templates:** No payment receipt email, credit collection confirmation, trial-ending, or staff role-change notices.
- **P2 Print/PDF:** Thermal path exists; PDF rasterizes HTML — fragile with modern CSS color spaces (partially mitigated).

Recommended program

1) One master email shell (header / body / footer) with token hex map for email clients. 2) Rewrite each template's hierarchy: what happened → what to do → when it expires → how to get help. 3) Align receipt/invoice print + PDF + email-of-receipt to the same settlement language. 4) Add the missing lifecycle emails listed in §6.

2. Email inventory (current system)

All live HTML is built as f-strings in EmailService (backend/app/core/maile r .py), sent via Resend.

Method	Trigger	Primary CTA	Brand state
send_password_reset	Forgot password	Reset password (sky #0284c7)	Slate header #0f172a
send_onboarding_setup	Self-serve signup	Set password & start trial (indigo)	Indigo SaaS
send_staff_invite	Owner invites staff	Accept invite	Mixed SaaS
send_trial_invoice	Trial started	Open Tawala (indigo)	Invoice table + indigo
send_welcome	Legacy/welcome	Varies	Legacy
send_testing	Management test	None	Diagnostic

2.1 Shared problems across templates

- Inline styles only — good for email clients — but duplicated per method (drift guaranteed).
- CTA colors are not DESIGN.md primary; users see indigo on web app petrol.
- Footer is minimal; no support path, no physical/company identity block for trust.
- No multipart plain-text alternative documented in code.
- Greeting defaults (“Valued User”) feel generic vs shop-owner tone.
- Preheader / preview text not set (inbox snippet uncontrolled).

3. Per-template friction & target

3.1 Password reset

User job: Recover account safely and return to the till quickly.

Friction: Stronger than others, but sky CTA and slate header do not match app; IP/time metadata is good but visually buried.

Target experience: Petrol header bar; single primary button “Reset password”; expiry in bold under CTA; secondary text link for raw URL; support line if this was not you.

3.2 Onboarding setup (verify + password + trial)

User job: Finish signup, trust the product, reach first value.

Friction: Indigo CTA; “Ndovu” plan name may be unknown; expiry minutes easy to miss; no preview of what happens after click.

Target experience: Hero line: “Confirm your email to start 14 days free.” CTA petrol. Bullet next steps under button. Expiry chip. Ignore-if-not-you.

3.3 Staff invite

User job: Accept invite, set password, open assigned branch.

Friction: Org/role context may be thin; same brand drift; unclear device guidance for cashiers.

Target experience: Show org name + role as fact row. CTA “Join {org}”. Note: shared till → use PIN after login. Expiry clear.

3.4 Trial invoice (zero amount)

User job: Understand trial is active; know amount due today is 0; open app.

Friction: Looks like a marketing email with an invoice table; indigo CTA; “invoice” may scare users expecting a charge.

Target experience: Title: “Your trial is active — KSh 0 due today.” Fact table: plan, window, amount. CTA “Open Tawala”. Soft note on upgrade before end date.

3.5 Welcome / testing

User job: Sanity and legacy paths.

Friction: Low priority; still should not ship indigo diagnostics to customers.

Target experience: Testing stays internal. Welcome folds into onboarding setup where possible.

4. Email sketches & wireframes (target master shell)

All emails share one shell. Only the middle “story block” changes.

4.1 Master shell (wireframe)

```
+-----+
| [preheader: hidden preview text 40-90 chars] |
+-----+
| #003F4E bar                                |
| TAWALA                                     tawala.nethub.co.ke |
+-----+
| CARD (white / #FAF9F9 edge)                |
|                                              |
| Eyebrow (optional)                        |
| Title (what happened)                     |
| Body (1-3 short paragraphs)               |
|                                              |
| [ PRIMARY CTA #003F4E ]                   |
|                                              |
| Expiry / security note                    |
| Fact rows (optional table)                |
| Raw link fallback (small muted)           |
|                                              |
+-----+
| Footer: support · privacy · ignore if unexpected |
+-----+
```

4.2 Password reset (hi-fi intent)

Title: Reset your Tawala password
 Body: We received a request for {email}. Link expires in {n} minutes.
 CTA: Reset password
 Secondary: If you did not request this, you can ignore this email.
 Meta: Request time · IP (muted)

4.3 Onboarding setup (hi-fi intent)

Eyebrow: 14-day free trial
 Title: Confirm your email to start selling
 Body: One step left – set a password. No card required.
 CTA: Set password & start trial
 Checklist: Add branch · Add products · Create staff PIN
 Expiry: Link expires in {n} minutes

4.4 Staff invite (hi-fi intent)

Title: You are invited to {Org name}
 Fact: Role · {Role} Invited by · {Owner}
 CTA: Accept invite
 Note: After joining, use your PIN on shared shop devices.
 Expiry: clear

4.5 Trial active / zero invoice (hi-fi intent)

Title: Your trial is active
 Badge: Amount due today KSh 0.00
 Table: Plan | Start | End | Amount due
 CTA: Open Tawala
 Foot: Upgrade or cancel before {end_date}

5. Receipts & invoices — current state

Primary UI: ReceiptClientView (print + PDF via html2canvas/jsPDF). Mode toggles receipt vs invoice via ?method=invoice. Post-sale screen: CompleteSaleClient (success card, not a full document).

5.1 Strengths (after theme work)

- Clear total hierarchy (amount-lg).
- Thermal-oriented print CSS ($\approx 72\text{--}80\text{mm}$).
- Separate actions: New sale / Print.
- Credit vs paid visual language on complete-sale (mint vs terracotta).

5.2 Friction & gaps

- **P1 Data fidelity:** Receipt still leans on cart store + placeholder branch block — not always the finalized sale record from API.
- **P1 Invoice depth:** Invoice mode is mostly a label change; missing buyer address, PIN/VAT fields, payment terms block required for real B2B credit.
- **P2 No email-of-receipt:** Customer cannot receive PDF/HTML receipt automatically after sale.
- **P2 QR / verification:** No scan-to-verify or sale reference prominence for disputes.
- **P2 Multi-copy:** No shop copy vs customer copy distinction.
- **P2 PDF pipeline:** Raster PDF can fail on CSS color functions; vector/HTML-to-PDF later is more robust.

6. Receipt & invoice target designs

6.1 Shared document anatomy

RECEIPT (paid now)	INVOICE / CREDIT (pay later)
-----	-----
Shop identity	Shop identity
Doc type: RECEIPT	Doc type: TAX INVOICE / CREDIT NOTE
Ref · Date · Cashier	Ref · Date · Due / terms
Customer (optional)	Customer (required) + contacts
Line items	Line items
Subtotal · Tax · Discount	Subtotal · Tax
TOTAL PAID (mint accent OK)	AMOUNT DUE (terracotta if open)
Payment method	“Collect later” + balance cue
Thank-you line	Payment instructions
Footer: Tawala + support	Footer: PIN/VAT if configured

6.2 On-screen wireframe (customer-facing)

+-----+		
[Back] Receipt / Invoice [...]		
+-----+		
TAWALA		
{Branch name}		
{Phone · location}		
+-----+		
Receipt no.		TWL-123456
Date		14 Sep 2026
Cashier		Wanjiku
+-----+		
Item	Qty	Amount
Cooking oil 2L	2	1,180.00
...		
+-----+		
Subtotal		x,xxx.xx
Tax		xxx.xx
TOTAL PAID / DUE		KSh xx,xxx.xx
(amount-lg, tabular)		
+-----+		
M-Pesa · matched · TJ7K...		
Thank you		
+-----+		
[New sale]		[Print]
+-----+		

6.3 Thermal hi-fi rules

- Width 72–80mm; pure black text on white for print; no petrol fills on thermal paper.
- Screen may use brand accents; print stylesheet forces black/white.
- Totals always tabular; currency prefix consistent (KSh).
- Reference ID large enough to read from photo.

6.4 Email “sale receipt” (missing today — proposed)

Subject: Receipt TWL-123456 · KSh 4,250.00
 Title: Payment received
 Fact rows: Branch · Date · Method · Ref
 CTA: View receipt online (optional)
 Attachment or button: Download PDF
 Footer: Support WhatsApp/email

7. Hi-fi token map for email (client-safe hex)

Email clients do not read CSS variables. Use this static map derived from DESIGN.md:

Role	Hex	Use
Primary / header bar	#003F4E	Header, primary CTA fill
Primary text on brand	#FFFFFF	CTA label, header wordmark
Body text	#121B1E	Titles, amounts
Muted	#5A6468	Secondary copy, meta
Surface / page bg	#F4F3F0	Outer email background
Card	#FFFFFF	Main content card
Border	#E5E3DC	Dividers, card edge
Success	#0F766E	Paid / matched badges
Warning / credit	#C1705B	Open balance, void
Error	#BA1A1A	Security alerts only

Forbidden in new templates: #4f46e5, #6366f1, #0284c7, #0f172a as primary brand, Tailwind-looking slate stacks.

8. Missing communications to add

Template	Why	Priority
Sale receipt email	Customer proof; reduces disputes	P1
Credit collected	Closes loop after collect flow	P1
Trial ending in 3 days	Prevents surprise lockout	P1
Invite reminder	Staff who never accepted	P2
Password changed	Security notice	P2
Paywall / limit reached	Upgrade adjacent to block	P2

9. Implementation priority

#	Work	Outcome
1	Master email shell + hex map helper in mailer	One place to restyle
2	Rewrite 4 live customer emails to shell + petrol CTA	Brand trust
3	Receipt/invoice from finalized sale API (not cart only)	Truthful document
4	Invoice fields for credit (customer, terms, amount due)	Real credit paper
5	Optional: email receipt + credit collected	Lifecycle complete

10. Acceptance criteria

- Every customer email uses master shell; primary CTA #003F4E; no indigo/sky brand CTAs.
- Subject + preheader describe the job in under 90 characters combined.
- Expiry and “ignore if unexpected” present on security-sensitive mails.
- Receipt/invoice totals tabular; print CSS black on white; reference readable.
- Invoice mode shows customer + amount due when sale is credit.
- Screenshot/PDF sample of each template stored under .reports/ for regression.

End of audit. Navbar sticky fix ships separately on theme branch (fixed + layout spacer). Email/receipt implementation should be proposed as its own Engineer Mode phase after approval.